

Business&economy **RAILWAY BUDGET**

**SONIA GANDHI AND BANERJEE IN KANPUR
AFTER FLAGGING OFF A SHATABDI**

They allege that the budget contains projects not cleared or approved by either the Planning Commission or the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs. Indeed, the budget document states that "it is proposed to update the surveys for the following lines and thereafter these will be processed through Planning Commission for necessary approvals". Banerjee has been accused of standing on formality. Citing a need to boost investment and connectivity in backward areas, the minister used the age-old premise of Socially Desirable Rail Connectivity Proposals to include as many as 114 new lines without any clearance.

Her opponents in the CPI(M) believe the budget "conceals gross failures" on the employment front with over 1.7 lakh vacancies and does not focus on safety. It has criticised the slashing of allocation by Rs 579 crore to the Railway Safety Fund despite 120 accidents. Said CPI veteran Gurudas Dasgupta, "With all these new trains and talk about ancillary investments, what happens to the existing trains? Most of them run behind schedule, particularly in suburban Bengal. The tracks in the state are just not up to it. She needed to take a hard look at that first. New trains and dreamy eyed half-measures will ensure confusion to the already existing chaos." Banerjee, apart from 10 new express trains, has promised five new railway lines and a huge expansion in the suburban network.

Banerjee's budget which has a singular Tagore face, is obviously meant for the Bengali, beginning from station interiors being modelled on Santiniketan styles to Bharat Tirtha pilgrimage trains (named after a poem by Tagore) to a special train to Bangladesh to time with the 150th birth anniversary of the poet. Not to forget the proposed Rabindra Museums at Howrah and Geetanjali Museum at Bolpur, the Santiniketan railway station. However, this has brought some criticism with Congress



THE 2011 TICKET COUNTER

**Gross Receipts
Rs 94,800 crore**

**Freight
Rs 62,489 crore**

**Passenger
Rs 26,127 crore**

**Expenditure
Rs 87,100 crore**

**Investment Outlay
Rs 41,426 crore**

**Operating Ratio
93.2%**

**Gross Budgetary Support
Rs 15,800 crore**

**Freight Target
944 mn tonnes up from
844 mn tonnes**

**Impact of Pay Commission
Rs 55,000 crore**

leader Nirbed Roy, who has been closely associated with the heritage Asiatic Society, saying, "I have not heard of worse tokenism. Museums are a different brand altogether. Will the Visva-Bharati allow personal belongings of Tagore to be exhibited at these two museums? If not, then you can't call these museums. At the most, they can be termed exhibition outlets." To keep the intellectual community happy, Banerjee has announced the setting up of a cultural complex in Howrah named after the famed thespian Sombhu Mitra.

It is obvious that in the bounty for Bengal and in an attempt to create a socially desirable face for Bengal, Banerjee has gone about her one-time Congress senior, former railway minister ABA Ghani Khan Choudhury, who during his tenure in the days of Indira Gandhi, had made Bengal a breeding ground for government jobs. Banerjee is following the Ghani Khan myth. Even years after his death, Khan's niece gets elected as MP purely by shouting slogans reminding voters of what her uncle did for the state, and North Bengal in particular. There is no reason why the formula that worked then will not work in the assembly polls for Banerjee.

with Bhavna Vij-Aurora

